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SPORTS EDITOR

Young ballplayers are jittery in early spring, even as high in the minors as Class A. And it is with this knowledge that Columbus Fox Manager Skeeter Newsome speaks about the kids on his club.

"Sometimes a kid needs only to hear the crowd cheering for him, when he makes a good play, to overcome that emptiness associated with starting off a season in strange surroundings. Gives him a feeling of belonging."

Newsome can talk at length about young ballplayers. He likes to work with them and watch them develop.

Reminds me of Andy Cohen, now managing Indianapolis this season.

Andy played a spell of second base for the old New York Giants under John McGraw. And he'll never forget those days.

"I was struggling, hoping to make the team," Andy recalled, "and one day I had an awful time the first few innings."

"I lost a couple of pop flies and almost got hit by one. Back on the bench I said to Mr. McGraw: 'That's a terrible air current out there today, sir; those whirlwinds make the ball do funny things.'"

"McGraw looked at me and said: 'Those aren't whirlwinds, young man. . . those are trade winds . . . and you're going to Minneapolis tomorrow' . . ."

John McGraw has been the subject of more baseball tales involving rookie ballplayers than perhaps any other man ever connected with the game. Most of them sparkle with humor.

Original No-Windup Pitcher

Bill Terry, president of the Sally League and famous New York Giant of days not too long ago, has a storehouse of McGraw stories. One of Bill's favorites is about how one of his Memphis, Tenn., boyhood pals entered and left the bigtime.

"The old man (John McGraw) signed this kid pitcher on my recommendation," points out Terry. "But the old man didn't pitch the kid. Then, the final day of the season, the old man told him he was pitching the windup of the double-header."

"And the kid said to McGraw: 'Sorry, not me. I've got reservations on the 4-45 for Memphis.'"

"The kid caught the train and that was the end of his career with the Giants."

Another favorite of Terry's about McGraw is the way the old man offered him the job of managing the Giants. Terry and McGraw had not spoken for a while season, due to a spring training incident, but McGraw respected Bill and one day he sent for him to come to his office.

"The first words the old man said to me since spring training were: 'Bill, I want you to manage the Giants.'"

"I didn't argue with him, I accepted," added Memphis Bill.

Geraghty Watched Double Play

Casey Stengel, I suppose, runs John McGraw a close second when it comes to stories about baseball. When Ben Geraghty was managing Jacksonville he was always good for a couple of Stengel yarns. One Ben likes to tell is about the time Casey gave him some advice as a base runner.

Stengel was managing the Boston Braves then and he sent Geraghty in as a pinch runner, with Charlie Workman at bat. As Geraghty started for first base, Casey stopped him, saying:

"Now don't get yourself caught off and watch for a double play."

Workman was a pull hitter to right and on the second pitch he lined the ball at Ray Sanders, playing first base. Sanders made a glove-hand stab, shoved out his left foot, tagged first base and completed an unassisted double play.

Stengel stood up, looked at his players seated in the dugout, and asked:

"Now, what else could I have told him?"

And here's one on Stengel from the Baseball Digest:

One hot day in Yankee Stadium, Casey made 11 trips to the mound for consultations with pitcher Allie Reynolds, who was wavering through one jam after another. When Stengel came out for the 11th time, Reynolds said to him:

"Skip, I'm not tired."

Casey, his jaws set tight, snapped: "No? Well, maybe you ain't, but I am, so you're coming outa there."

Baseball has produced some colorful characters.

Doak Just Got Careless

Uncle Wilbert Robinson, the late manager of the old Brooklyn Dodgers, is another colorful character who flavored many a baseball story. One dates back to the old Baker Bowl, in Philadelphia, where it was a rare game, indeed, when each side didn't score at least a half-dozen runs.

One chap who never seemed to mind the pitching assignment at Baker Bowl was Bill Doak, the spitballer. And Uncle Wilbert invariably nominated him.

Doak went into the ninth inning one day with a miraculous 1-0 lead. When the first hitter opened the frame with a triple, it was only the second hit Bill had yielded. The worried Uncle Robbie waddled out to the mound.

"You in trouble, Bill?" he asked.

"Naw," said Bill. "With that big lead I just got careless."

Oa, yes. He did win the game.

Off the Sports Hook

The second game of the 1936 World Series was the longest nine-inning Series game in history. It lasted three hours, 26 minutes. Brooklyn beat the Yankees, 13-8.

Playing Manager Dick Slater of the Nashville Vols played 145 games at first base for San Diego last season.